

Credit - Drishti Ias

## 20th Statistics Day and SDGs-National Indicator Framework Progress Report 2026



Source: PIB

### Why in News?

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The **Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI)** celebrated the **20th Statistics Day** on **29 th June 2026** . The event was organized to commemorate the **133rd Birth Anniversary of Prof. P. C. Mahalanobis** , recognizing his invaluable contribution to the national statistical system.

- On this occasion, MoSPI also released the **Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) - National Indicator Framework Progress Report, 2026** , tracking India's progress towards the SDGs.

### What is National Statistics Day?

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- **National Statistics Day:** The Government of India designated **29th June** as 'Statistics Day' in **2007** . It serves as an annual tribute to the legacy of Prof. P.C. Mahalanobis.
- **Objective:** To create public awareness, especially among the youth, about the role of statistics in socio-economic planning and policy formulation.
- **Theme for 2026: “Unlocking the Potential of Administrative Data.”** It highlights the shift towards utilizing data generated through everyday government operations (like tax records, registries, and welfare enrollments) for evidence-based policymaking, rather than relying solely on traditional, resource-heavy sample surveys.

### Prof. P.C. Mahalanobis

- **About:** Prasanta Chandra Mahalanobis (1893–1972) is widely regarded as the **Father of Indian Statistics** . His visionary approach laid the foundation for India’s modern statistical architecture.
- **Key Contributions:**
  - **Institutional Builder:** He founded the **Indian Statistical Institute (ISI) in 1931** (declared an 'Institution of National Importance' by Parliament in 1959). Furthermore, his vision directly led to the establishment of the **National Sample Survey (NSS) in 1950** and the **Central Statistical Organisation (CSO)** .
    - He also founded **Sankhya** , India's first statistical journal, in **1933** .
  - **Architect of India's Economic Planning:** He was a key member of the first **Planning Commission**

of independent India.

- He played a highly influential role in drafting **India's Second Five-Year Plan (1956-1961)** , which was fundamentally based on his renowned **four-sector model (the Mahalanobis Model)** that prioritized rapid, heavy industrialization and capital investment.
- **Mahalanobis Distance:** Formulated in 1930, he introduced Mahalanobis Distance, a metric used to find the **distance between a point and a distribution**, widely used today in machine learning, cluster analysis, and classification techniques.
- **Large-Scale Sample Surveys:** He pioneered the concept of using large-scale sample surveys for data collection, proving that a well-designed sample could provide highly accurate estimates for a massive population at a fraction of the cost of a census.
- **Practical Governance and Flood Control:** A fierce advocate for applied statistics, his innovative data analysis was successfully utilized by the Indian Government to design effective **flood prevention measures** and yield important meteorological discoveries.
- **Global Recognition and National Honors:** He served as the **Chairman of the United Nations Subcommission on Statistical Sampling (1947-1951)** , was elected a **Fellow of the Royal Society, London (1945)** , and was awarded India's second-highest civilian award, the **Padma Vibhushan** , in 1968 .



## What are the Key Findings of the SDGs-National Indicator Framework Progress Report, 2026?

- **SDG 1 - No Poverty):** **Multidimensional poverty** declined from **24.85% (2015-16) to 14.96% (2019-21)** .
  - The population covered by social protection floors rose from **22.0% (2019) to 65.3% (2026)** .
  - **Key drivers:** **PM Jan Dhan Yojana** , **Direct Benefit Transfers**.
- **SDG 2 - Zero Hunger:** **Child underweight** (under 5 years) reduced from **35.7% (2015-16) to 31.8% (2023-24)** .
  - Child stunting declined from **38.4% (2015-16) to 29.3% (2023-24)** .
  - **Key schemes:** **POSHAN Abhiyaan**, and **PM POSHAN** .

- **SDG 3 - Good Health & Well-Being:** **Maternal Mortality Ratio (MMR)** improved from **122 (2015-17) to 87 (2022-24)** per 1,00,000 live births.
  - Skilled health personnel birth attendance rose from **81.4% to 91.3%** (NFHS-4 to NFHS-6).
  - **The under-five mortality rate** declined from **43 (2015) to 28 (2024)** per 1,000 live births. **Neonatal mortality rate** fell from **25 (2015) to 18 (2024)** per 1,000 live births.
  - **TB treatment** coverage improved significantly from **71% (2020) to 92% (2024)** .
  - **Key drivers:** **National Health Mission, Ayushman Bharat, Janani Suraksha Yojana, Mission Indradhanush.**
- **SDG 4 - Quality Education:** **Gross Enrolment Ratio** in higher secondary education rose from **48.32 (2015-16) to 48.32 (2024-25)** .
  - Schools with internet facilities expanded from **46.30 (2015-16) to 84.20% (2024-25)** .
  - **Key enablers:** **Samagra Shiksha Abhiyan, and National Education Policy 2020.**
- **SDG 5 - Gender Equality:** Sex Ratio at Birth improved from **896 (2015-17) to 918 (2022-24)** .
  - Female-to-male Labour Force Participation Rate ratio improved from **0.43 (2020-21) to 0.52 (2025)** .
  - Women-exclusive SHGs in bank-linked SHGs grew from **88.92% (2015-16) to 96.00% (2025-26)** .
  - **Key enablers:** **Beti Bachao Beti Padhao, SHG network expansion, and Gender Budgeting.**
- **SDG 6 - Clean Water & Sanitation:** Households with piped water supply (rural) rose from **48.15% (2021-22) to 81.81% (2025-26)** .
  - Wastewater processed increased from **17.97% (2015-16) to 82.20% (2025-26)** - a dramatic rise.
  - Water-use efficiency score improved from **2.89 USD/m<sup>3</sup> (2020) to 5.30 USD/m<sup>3</sup> (2023)** .
  - **Key missions:** **Jal Jeevan Mission , Swachh Bharat Mission, and Atal Bhujal Yojana .**
- **SDG 7 - Affordable & Clean Energy:** **100% household electrification** achieved.
  - Renewable energy generating capacity grew from **64.04 watts per capita (2014-15) to 193.36 watts per capita (2025-26)** , nearly 300% increase.
  - Energy intensity (primary energy per unit of GDP) declined from **0.2556 to 0.1329 MJ/Rupee** (2015-16 to 2024-25), reflecting improved energy efficiency.
  - **Key drivers:** **Saubhagya scheme , PM-KUSUM , PLI for Solar PV Modules.**
- **SDG 8 - Decent Work & Economic Growth:** Unemployment rate declined from **6.1% (2017-18) to 3.1% (2025)** .
  - Tourism growth rate stood at **15.01% (2023-24)** , reflecting sectoral recovery and expansion.
  - **Key drivers:** **Startup India, PM Mudra Yojana, Swadesh Darshan 2.0 , e-Visa expansion.**
- **SDG 9 - Industry, Innovation & Infrastructure:** Manufacturing sector employment as a proportion of total employment improved from **11.40% (2022-23) to 12.14% (2025)** .
  - Population covered by at least 4G mobile network reached **99.51% (2025)** .
  - **Key enablers:** **BharatNet , Atal Innovation Mission, Startup India .**
- **SDG 10- Reduced Inequalities:** **Gini Coefficient** for rural household expenditure improved from **0.28 (2011-12) to 0.23 (2023-24)** , indicating lower inequality.
  - Urban Gini Coefficient also improved from **0.36 (2011-12) to 0.28 (2023-24)** .
  - The ratio of female-to-male professional and technical workers improved to **51.3% (2025)** , approaching parity.
  - **Key instruments:** **Pradhan Mantri Jan Dhan Yojana , PM-KISAN, Accessible India Campaign,**

## Direct Benefit Transfers.

- **SDG 11 - Sustainable Cities & Communities:** Percentage of wards with 100% door-to-door waste collection rose from **43 (2015-16) to 97 (2025-26)** .
  - Percentage of waste processed rose from **17.97% (2015-16) to 82.20% (2025-26)** .
  - India has adopted and implemented a **national disaster risk reduction strategy aligned with the Sendai Framework (2015-2030)**.
  - **Key initiatives:** **AMRUT, Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana (PMAY), Smart Cities Mission.**
- **SDG 12 - Responsible Consumption & Production:** Number of waste recycling plants installed grew from **829 (2019-20) to 3,236 (2025-26)** .
  - **Post-harvest storage losses** of wheat and rice from central/state pool stocks declined nearly to zero ( **-0.02 in 2025-26** ), reflecting better storage management.
  - **Key policies:** Extended Producer Responsibility (EPR) frameworks for plastic waste, e-waste, batteries and tyres; circular economy promotion.
- **SDG 13 - Climate Action:** India has updated **Nationally Determined Contribution (2031-2035)** and long-term strategies under the **UNFCCC and Paris Agreement**.
  - Compliance of industries with environmental standards improved from **86.25% (2018) to 91.82% (2024)** .
  - Guided by **NAPCC** and its eight national missions; all States/UTs have prepared or updated State Action Plans on Climate Change.
- **SDG 14- Life Below Water:** Maximum Sustainable Yield (MSY) in fishing increased from **3.078 million tonne/year (2015-16) to 5.311 million tonne/year (2025-26)** .
  - India is in compliance with international laws for the conservation and sustainable use of oceans and marine resources.
  - **Key interventions:** Mangrove plantation, coral transplantation, shelterbelt development, artificial reefs, coral reef monitoring.
- **SDG 15 - Life on Land:** Forest cover as a percentage of total geographical area increased from **21.34% (2019) to 21.76% (2023)** .
  - The area of Ramsar (wetland) sites as a percentage of total wetland area more than doubled from **4.15% (2016) to 8.66% (2026)** .
  - **Key programmes:** **Green India Mission , Project Tiger , Project Elephant , Nagar Van Yojana, National Biodiversity Strategy & Action Plan (2024-2030)** aligned with Global Biodiversity Framework).
- **SDG 16 - Peace, Justice & Strong Institutions:** The number of judges increased from 1.33 per lakh population in 2016 to 1.55 in 2024, while the number of courts rose from 1.82 to 1.93 per lakh population during the same period.
  - Aadhaar coverage reached 95.67% in 2025-26, and India continues to maintain an **independent National Human Rights Institution in compliance with the Paris Principles**.
- **SDG 17 - Partnerships for the Goals :** India's share in global merchandise exports increased from 1.62% in 2015 to 1.70% in 2024.
  - Share in global commercial services exports rose significantly from 3.11% to 4.35% during the same period, reflecting the country's growing presence in global trade.

# National Indicator Framework (NIF)

- The **National Indicator Framework (NIF)** is the Government of India's primary statistical framework for monitoring progress towards the **17 Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs)** .
- Developed by **MoSPI** in consultation with **NITI Aayog, UN agencies, and other stakeholders** , it currently comprises **277 national indicators (2026)** covering all SDGs.
- The framework is **periodically updated by the High-Level Steering Committee (HLSC)** to align with the **Global Indicator Framework (GIF)** and national priorities.
- It also supports **localized SDG monitoring** through **State Indicator Frameworks (SIFs)** and **District Indicator Frameworks (DIFs)** .

## Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

### 1. Why is Statistics Day observed in India?

**Statistics Day** is observed annually on **29 June** to commemorate the birth anniversary of **Prof. P.C. Mahalanobis** and promote awareness about the role of statistics in evidence-based policymaking and socio-economic planning.

### 2. What is the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) - National Indicator Framework (NIF)?

The **National Indicator Framework (NIF)** is India's official framework for monitoring progress on all **17 SDGs** using nationally identified indicators, enabling periodic assessment of development outcomes.

### 3. What was the theme of Statistics Day 2026 and why is it significant?

The theme, "**Unlocking the Potential of Administrative Data**," emphasizes the use of government-generated administrative records for timely, cost-effective, and evidence-based policymaking, reducing dependence on traditional sample surveys.

### 4. What are the major contributions of Prof. P.C. Mahalanobis?

Prof. Mahalanobis founded the **Indian Statistical Institute (ISI)** , established the **National Sample Survey (NSS)** , introduced the **Mahalanobis Distance** , and played a pivotal role in India's statistical system and the **Second Five-Year Plan** .

[Watch Video on YouTube: [▶ https://www.youtube.com/embed/KmkTI0bZn\\_0](https://www.youtube.com/embed/KmkTI0bZn_0) ]

## UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Questions (PYQs)

**Q. With reference to India's Five-Year Plans, which of the following statements is/are correct? (2019)**

1. From the Second Five-Year Plan, there was a determined thrust towards substitution of basic and capital good industries.
2. The Fourth Five-Year Plan adopted the objective of correcting the earlier trend of increased concentration of wealth and economic power.
3. In the Fifth Five-Year Plan, for the first time, the financial sector was included as an integral part of the Plan.

**Select the correct answer using the code given below:**

- (a) 1 and 2 only
- (b) 2 only
- (c) 3 only
- (d) 1, 2 and 3

**Ans: (a)**

**Q. Sustainable development is described as the development that meets the needs of the present without compromising the ability of future generations to meet their own needs. In this perspective, inherently the concept of sustainable development is intertwined with which of the following concepts? (2010)**

- (a) Social justice and empowerment
- (b) Inclusive Growth
- (c) Globalization
- (d) Carrying capacity

**Ans: (d)**

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### ***Mains***

**Q. Access to affordable, reliable, sustainable and modern energy is the sine qua non to achieve Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs).” Comment on the progress made in India in this regard. (2018)**



# Mandu’s Khurasani Imli Gets GI Tag



Source: ET

Mandu’s(M.P) iconic Baobab fruit, locally known as Khurasani Imli, has received a **Geographical Indication (GI) tag**, giving it official recognition and protection.

- **About Khurasani Imli:** It is a light green fruit with a **tangy sweet-sour taste**, known for its **unique nutritional, medicinal, and cultural value** in the Mandu region.
- **About the Baobab Tree:** The Baobab tree, scientifically called *Adansonia digitata* , is famous for its huge water-storing trunk and **inverted-tree-like branches**, making it a major landmark of Mandu.
  - **Historical Origin:** The tree is believed to have been introduced to **Mandu nearly six centuries ago by Afghan and Arab traders** and later adapted to the local climate and terrain.
  - **Local Concentration:** Mandu has India’s largest naturally occurring population of Baobab trees, with officials estimating more than 1,000 trees in the region.
  - **Traditional Uses:** Tribal communities have long used the **fruit pulp, juice, seeds, and dried bark** for health purposes, including treating diabetes, digestive problems, fever, and fatigue.
- **Impact:** The tag is expected to benefit tribal families through **better income, organised marketing, cooperatives, value-added products, new plantations, and conservation** , though dedicated government conservation programmes and scientific research are still lacking.
- **Significance:** The GI tag is expected to improve branding, marketing and value-added industries around Baobab-based products, directly benefiting tribal families involved in collection and processing.

### WHAT IS A GI TAG?

- > A GI tag is a geographical indication of an item which is specific to a particular place
- > GI status can be sought for agricultural products, handicrafts, handloom and food products
- > The RGI (registration of geographical indications) logo given to a particular product can only be used by registered and authorised users
- > When marketed, a GI tagged product must carry a logo showing its place of origin
- > Civil and criminal proceedings can be initiated against those using the logo in unauthorised manner

### HOW TO APPLY?

- > An association or collective body can apply to GI Registry
- > Application should be backed by proof of uniqueness, historical records to show proof of origin, quality and special character
- > After rounds of verification, presentation and meetings, if registry is satisfied, application goes to GI Registry journal
- > If application receives no opposition within four months, it gets the GI tag

Read More: [India's Geographical Indication Landscape](#)

# Delhi Electric Vehicle Policy 2.0



Source: TH

# Why in News?

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Recently, the Delhi government notified its new **Electric Vehicle Policy 2.0** , with the policy likely to come into effect from 1st July 2026 and remain valid till **31st March 2030** .

## What are the Key Provisions of Delhi Electric Vehicle Policy 2.0?

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- **About:** The policy aims to make Delhi a **leading electric mobility hub** by focusing on **high-polluting and high-use vehicle segments** such as two-wheelers, three-wheelers, commercial goods vehicles, school buses, aggregator fleets and government transport fleets.
- **Target:** It aims to achieve **at least 30% electrification of Delhi's total vehicle fleet** by 31st March 2030, building on the success of the **EV policy 2020**, under which Delhi achieved around **14% EV penetration by 2025**.
- **Mandates:** From 1st January 2027, only **electric three-wheelers and N1 category trucks** will be registered in Delhi; from 1st April 2028, only electric two-wheelers will be registered. Already registered fossil-fuel vehicles will be allowed to complete their full lifecycle.
- **Buses:** School buses will have to **convert at least 10% of their fleet to EVs within two years of notification of the policy** , with a broader target of 30% electrification by 2030.
- **Funding:** The government has **allocated ₹7,000 crore for policy implementation**, with an overall investment plan of ₹15,000 crore, including charging infrastructure, purchase incentives and scrapping incentives.
- **Incentives:** EV buyers will get purchase incentives, road tax exemption and registration fee waiver. Two-wheelers will receive incentives up to **₹30,000 in the first year, ₹20,000 in the second year and ₹10,000 in the third year**. Three-wheelers will receive ₹50,000, ₹40,000 and ₹30,000 respectively, while N1 commercial trucks will get a subsidy up to ₹1 lakh in the first year.
- **Scrapping:** Scrapping incentives will be provided for **vehicles below BS-IV emission norms** , including around ₹10,000 for two-wheelers, ₹25,000 for three-wheelers, ₹1 lakh for four-wheelers, ₹50,000 for N1 trucks and ₹15,000 for Gramin Seva units completing their lifecycle.
- **Infrastructure:** The policy plans to install more than **30,000 public charging points**, with around ₹1,000 crore allocated for charging infrastructure.
- **Implementation Agencies:** The **Transport Department will act as the nodal agency** for implementing the policy, while Delhi Transco Ltd. will develop charging infrastructure in coordination with the power department and distribution companies.
- **Exemption:** Electric N2 trucks carrying loads between 3.5 and 12 tonnes will be exempted from **"No Entry" timings for 10 years** , but this benefit will apply only to the first 1,000 N2 trucks purchased within three months of policy notification.
- **Hybrids:** The policy clearly **excludes hybrid vehicles from subsidies**, as the government wants to focus only on pure EVs because of their zero-emission benefits.

## What are the Challenges and Significance of Electric Vehicles?

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| Challenges                                                                                                             | Significance                                                                                                           |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>High upfront cost</b> of EVs may affect auto drivers, delivery workers and small commercial vehicle owners.         | Helps <b>reduce vehicular pollution</b> , a major contributor to Delhi's poor air quality.                             |
| <b>Limited access to affordable financing</b> may slow adoption in vulnerable segments.                                | Focuses on <b>high-impact segments like two-wheelers, three-wheelers</b> and goods vehicles.                           |
| <b>Charging infrastructure</b> may face issues of poor maintenance, power outages and limited access.                  | Shifts Delhi from <b>subsidy-led EV adoption</b> to mandate-based structural change.                                   |
| <b>Grid stress</b> may increase due to large-scale EV charging, especially in dense urban areas.                       | <b>Encourages investment</b> in EV manufacturing, charging infrastructure, battery services and fleet electrification. |
| <b>Battery waste, recycling, land availability</b> and livelihood transition for repair workers remain major concerns. | Can make Delhi a model for other Indian states in urban electric mobility transition.                                  |

## Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

### 1. What is Delhi EV Policy 2026?

Delhi EV Policy 2026 is a policy framework aimed at promoting electric vehicles, reducing vehicular pollution and achieving at least 30% electrification of Delhi's vehicle fleet by March 31, 2030.

### 2. When will only electric two-wheelers be registered in Delhi?

Only electric two-wheelers will be registered in Delhi from April 1, 2028.

### 3. When will only electric three-wheelers and N1 trucks be registered?

Only electric three-wheelers and N1 trucks will be registered from January 1, 2027.

### 4. Are hybrid vehicles eligible for subsidy under the policy?

No, the policy does not provide subsidies for hybrid vehicles and focuses only on pure electric vehicles.

### 5. What is the purchase incentive for electric two-wheelers?

Electric two-wheelers will receive up to ₹30,000 in the first year, ₹20,000 in the second year and ₹10,000 in the third year.

[Watch Video on YouTube: [▶ https://www.youtube.com/embed/XiaeYX6-Mgg](https://www.youtube.com/embed/XiaeYX6-Mgg) ]

# UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Questions (PYQs)

## *Prelims*

**Q. With reference to the role of biofilters in Recirculating Aquaculture System, consider the following statements: (2023)**

1. Biofilters provide waste treatment by removing uneaten fish feed.
2. Biofilters convert ammonia present in fish waste to nitrate.
3. Biofilters increase phosphorus as nutrient for fish in water.

**How many of the statements given above are correct?**

- (a) Only one
- (b) Only two
- (c) All three
- (d) None

**Ans: (b)**

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## *Mains*

**Q. Explain the purpose of Green Grid Initiative launched at World Leaders Summit of COP26 UN Climate Change Conference in Glasgow in November 2021. When was this idea first floated in the International Solar Alliance? (2021)**